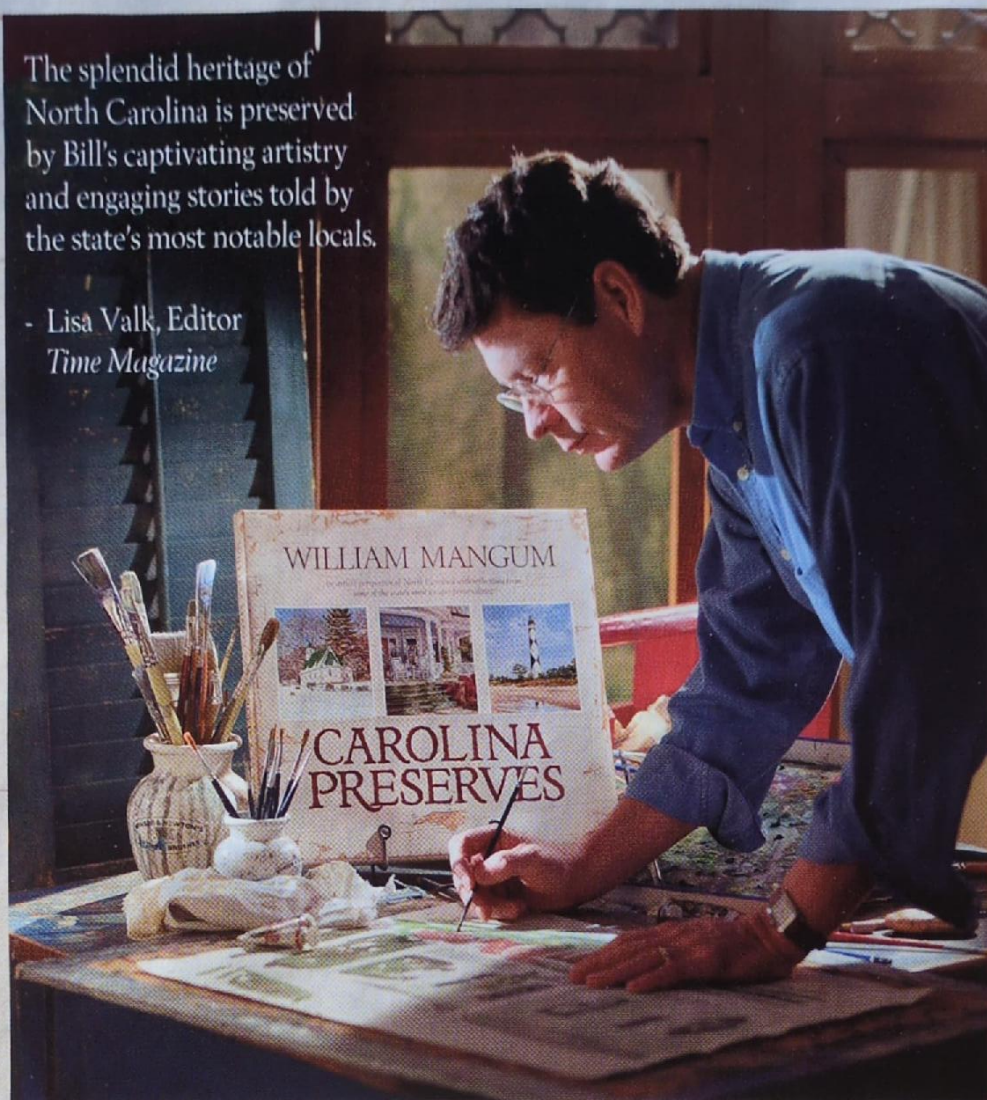


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- Lisa Valk, Editor
Time Magazine



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On Wings and Prayers

A special center near Charlotte
takes injured birds of prey under its wing
and helps many of them soar again.

STORY BY MARSHALL ELLIS

"There is something good to be said about anything that provides people with the knowledge that there are other animals besides themselves on this planet."

— John Lukas
Director

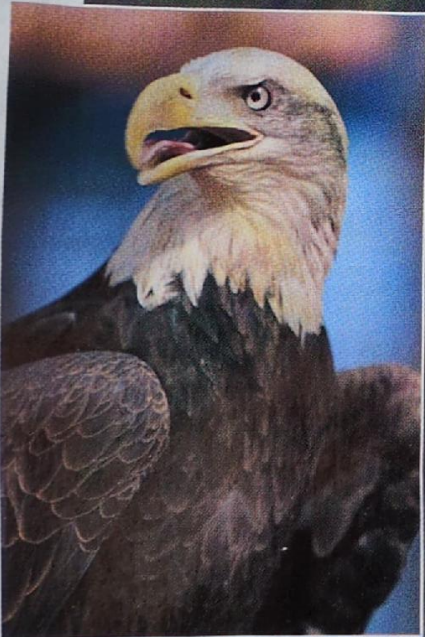
*White Oak Plantation Conservation Center
Yulee, Florida*

In 1782, while contemplating a national symbol, the Continental Congress selected the bald eagle. Benjamin Franklin objected — he voted for the turkey — but the consensus was that the eagle seemed the better choice for a young country in need of a strong symbol. Nearly 220 years later, it still seems the better choice, as people everywhere marvel when they see one.

I first marveled at bald eagles in 1977, when I was 19 and working at a summer camp on the Pamlico River in Beaufort County. At mid-summer, an eagle took up residence just downstream, and at twilight several of us would putter out in skiffs and wait for the great, white-headed bird to appear. Then as now, bald eagles were a rare sight, and this one produced an eruption of goose flesh. One of my abiding memories from that summer came on a sweltering evening when I stood and hollered "there it is!" as it broached the tree line. Wheeling to watch as it soared by impossibly close, I barely avoided flopping into the river.

Eagles are, of course, but one among the many birds of prey that ply North Carolina's skies. Known as raptors — from the Latin for "to seize and carry away" — these hunters include hawks, owls, falcons, vultures, and eagles. All share a select set of characteristics: a carnivorous diet,

With long hooked bills, broad wings, and powerful toes, American bald eagles have recently returned to North Carolina to nest near lakes and the coast.



Jason Williams

keen eyesight for spotting prey, vise-like talons for the capture, and a hooked bill for rendering the catch of the day into bite-size morsels. Their diets consist primarily of small rodents, and their role as predator marks them as a keystone atop the ornithological food web. Their presence is an important indication of that web's overall health, because trouble in the penthouse augurs poorly for the species in the basement.

Raptors have long been admired by cultures the world over, but they have also been wrongly labeled as winged varmints. Shot, trapped, and poisoned in staggering numbers, even the federal government got into the act. In a richly ironic twist, it paid ranchers a bounty on bald eagles into the early 20th century. Contemporary calamities have included population crashes fostered by pesticides, particularly the notorious DDT.

But times changed, raptor ecology came into its own as a scientific discipline, and thanks to a combination of education, legal protection, and the sanc-

tuary offered by remote landscapes, many species have managed to recoup their losses. Success stories include the peregrine falcon and the bald eagle, both recently removed from the endangered species list. More important, a network of raptor rehabilitation centers began to save injured birds that previously would have died.

Today, thousands of injured raptors are rehabilitated and released annually by these centers, and one of the country's finest facilities occupies an idyllic site on 57 wooded acres at the Latta Plantation Nature Preserve, 20 minutes north of Charlotte. Established as a nonprofit educational and research institution in 1981, the Carolina Raptor Center not only repairs injured raptors, it's also a place where people like you and me can see and learn about them up close. Visitors who walk the forested nature trail encounter nearly 100 raptors from 20 species, all of them native to North Carolina. Another 100 or so birds form the center's avian education corps; they're the stars in the center's phenomenal education programs.

Nearly all of these birds have suffered permanent injuries and



Not the prettiest of the lot but the turkey vulture ply North Carolina's skies and help indicate the overall health of our food web.

not be released to the wild. Happily though, they have and a new life here and are helping to make a difference at a time when we are increasingly disconnected from the natural world. When I joined Alan Barnhardt, the center's executive director, for a tour on a spring morning, I was reminded of why that eagle so captured my attention all those years ago. These birds have rightly been called "masters of the sky," and after you visit this place, you understand why the people who work here believe raptors can put a little wonder into your day.

Hoots and screeches

In September 1975, when an injured broad-winged hawk was delivered to the biology department at UNC Charlotte, ornithologist Richard Brown and his students nursed the owl back to health and released it. More birds arrived over the next few years, and short on space, students even took to using cardboard boxes beneath dorm beds. By 1981 the need for a real rehabilitation center was obvious, and the center was born.

Temporary quarters sprang up in the basement of the UNCC biology department, and hoots and screeches soon filled the halls. Wooden cages replaced cardboard boxes, free veterinarian care was arranged, and costs were defrayed through a gift shop that operated from a closet. By 1984, with more than 200 birds arriving annually, another move was made, this time to Latta Plantation. The new site proved to be more homestead than home, however, and the still all-volunteer staff perse-

vered without water, power, or phones. Water was hauled from the lake via bucket brigade, and when two mobile homes arrived in 1985, they pulled triple duty as staff quarters, hospital, and storage space.

With time, a real rehab center appeared in those woods. Permanent aviaries were built, the nature trail took shape, and in 1986 the first paid staff arrived. Today, the center boasts a visitor center, hospital, paid staff of 14 (including some of the finest rehabilitation folks in the business), and nearly 150 volunteers who donate more than 18,000 hours each year. What began with a single bird has been transformed into an institution of international prominence in the raptor conservation world. It is, says Barnhardt, "a great story," and he notes with justifiable pride that the CRC is the sort of operation that makes other rehab centers envious.

Serving the community

At first blush, Barnhardt might seem an unlikely choice for this business. Although an accomplished outdoorsman who knows more about the natural world than the average bear, he is neither ecologist nor ornithologist by training. Of raptors, he says, "I knew they ate mice and squirrels, and I knew about things like DDT, but I didn't know the finer differences between species." He arrived in August 1999, having walked away from 24 years as the owner of a prosperous wilderness outfitting business that had, in the end, "left me burned out."

Mark Bashista



So he sold the business, planned a mountaineering vacation with his daughter, and waited to see what came along.

What came along was the CRC, and he was very impressed by what he saw — an enormously talented staff, an unimaginably dedicated group of volunteers, and a board of directors committed to expanding the center's profile. "I couldn't find a downside to this job," he says, and the businessman in him recognized an opportunity for what he has called "Charlotte's best-kept secret" to serve the community in a more substantial way. The board agreed to wait for Barnhardt to complete his father-daughter trip; nearly a year later, as we walk the trails and I watch him deftly handle a variety of birds, his enthusiasm is infectious. He admits with a laugh that he spends as much time here as he did when he was in business, but he also says that "this has been a whole lot of fun, and I'm still learning a lot."

One of the reasons it's fun is the extraordinary CRC staff. "Because of that, we do several things well here," Barnhardt says. Most noticeable is the educational program, which last year took the hugely popular "Wild Wings" show on the road to 54,000 schoolchildren in some 100 cities in the Carolinas. Another 35,000 visited the center, and outreach exhibitions reached an additional 120,000. On the day I visited, the parking lot, visitor center, and nature trail echoed with the excited chatter of adults and children, and at every turn visitors were engaged. Linger at the eagle aviary — largest in the Southeast — I counted nine eagles and eavesdropped as a CRC staffer discussed eagle biology with a rapt audience. Good stuff. The bulk of the center's annual budget goes to the education program, and Barnhardt hopes to soon extend it to audiences in Atlanta and southern Virginia.

None of this could happen without the staff's sterling reha-

bilitation work. Since 1984 the center has handled nearly 8,000 injured birds; in 1999 it received 550 birds — victims of cars, gunshots, entanglement in fences and fishing lines, electric shock, traps, and poisons. The injuries are frequently severe, and recovery can take months of painstaking effort by bird and rehabilitator alike. With no full-time veterinarian on staff, the center relies on local vets who donate their time and skill. So just how good are these people? The overall release rate last year for birds that survived the first 24 hours was an astonishing 63 percent.

On the day I visited, I learned that 40 birds had arrived just that month. I watched as three staffers gently tended to the newest arrival, a great horned owl with a severe wing injury, and learned it would have plenty of company: Another 96 birds were already in rehab. Every loss is keenly felt, but there is little time to relax. Much of the workload is shouldered by volunteers, all of whom receive extensive training in bird identification, anatomy, natural history, handling, and care. It's one of the most respected training programs in the field, and unlike most rehab centers, the CRC volunteers fill every role. Much of the heavy lifting is also done by them, and Barnhardt notes matter-of-factly that without them, the CRC would surely be adrift.

Ground zero in the rehab program is the gleaming 4,000-square-foot hospital that opened in 1998. Complete with examination rooms and sophisticated laboratory equipment, it's a long way from the old days in a mobile home with rotting floors. Birds admitted to the hospital follow a well-established protocol. Diagnosis and treatment are followed by a stay in an outdoor aviary to rest and build strength. Next comes flight training in a large outdoor cage and, finally, a stint in "mouse school," where they must prove that their hunting skills are

Friends of animals abound

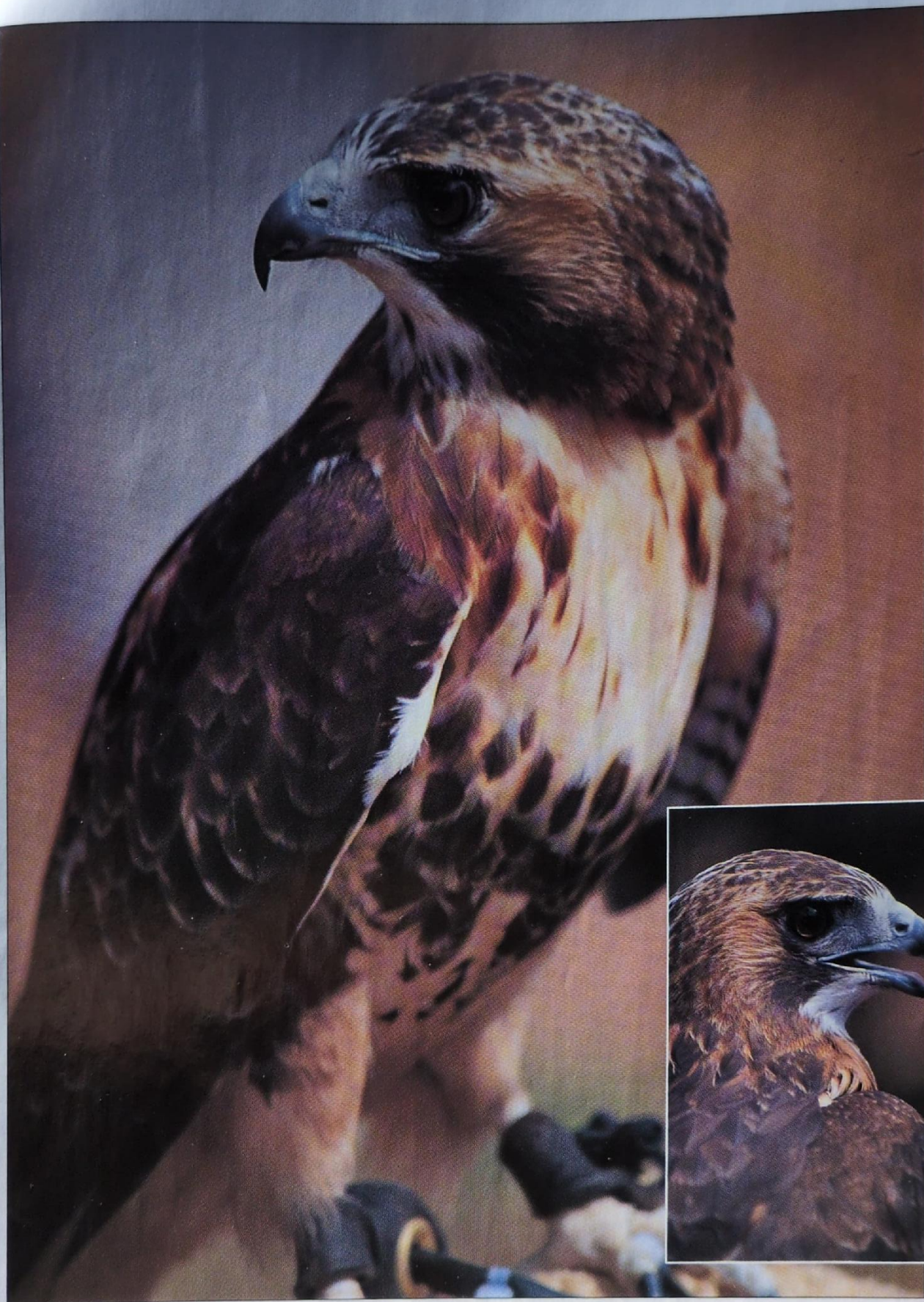
The National Wildlife Rehabilitators Association (www.nwrawildlife.org), serves as a clearinghouse for information on all types of wildlife rehabilitation. The Carolina Raptor Center is just one among dozens of raptor rehab facilities across the country and is generally considered to be North Carolina's flagship site. Like the CRC, most raptor centers handle all types of raptors. Notable programs include the World Center for Birds of Prey in Boise, Idaho; the Raptor Center at the University of Minnesota; and the Cornell Raptor Program at Cornell University. Other programs, such as the Peregrine Fund, concentrate on a single species.

Just as the CRC works solely with injured raptors, other centers have

similar specialties. Examples include American Tortoise Rescue in California, Pelican Fund in Florida, Marine Mammal Center in California, Appalachian Bear Center in Tennessee, and Reptile Adoption, Rehabilitation and Education in New York. Most of these centers are non-profit educational institutions, and all share a common goal of repairing and returning injured animals to their natural environments. If you find an injured bird, you should immediately contact the CRC, the N.C. Wildlife Resources Commission, or an experienced rehabilitator in your area. If you're unsure what steps to take, here are some important guidelines:

• Get help immediately. Any delay reduces the bird's chances for survival.

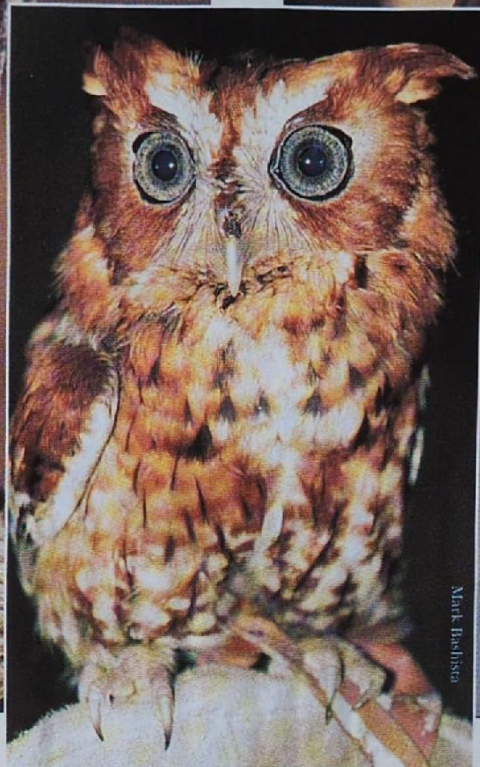
- Do not attempt to handle an injured bird; cover it with a towel, blanket or jacket and wait for the experts to arrive. Improper handling can fatally stress the animal and you could be seriously hurt since injured birds will still try to defend themselves with their talons and beaks.
- Do not feed or water injured raptors. Feeding at the wrong time may be fatal, as the bird might not be able to digest solid food properly.
- If you find a baby raptor, be aware that it may not need your help. Baby raptors frequently spend time out of the nest while learning to fly. In addition, do not feed baby birds, as improper feeding will kill them. Always call for advice and assistance from knowledgeable rehabilitators.



A day-active bird of prey, the red-tailed hawk has a short hooked bill for tearing meat and strong claws for killing and carrying prey.



In rehab at the center are the horned owl ...



... the screech owl ...



...and the barred owl.

intact. Then it's back to the place of rescue for release.

Because it's essential that the birds retain their wildness, those deemed releasable are treated in isolation to minimize stress and human contact. Permanently disabled birds become full-time residents and begin training for a place in the educational program. Visitors can assist in the rehabilitation work through the center's popular Adopt-a-Bird program, in which they pay a one-year adoption fee for a species of their choice; the staff assigns a resident bird and keeps them updated on its progress.

When worlds collide

As I walked among the cages housing the educational birds, I was reminded repeatedly of how harshly the modern and natural worlds collide. A barn owl named Spirit arrived here the day after Christmas in 1997, victim of an automobile crash. Next door, Hannah, an American kestrel, was raised — but then abandoned — by humans. Unable to forage naturally, she arrived in spring of 1998. Zlaty, a golden eagle, has but one wing. And Dudley, a temperamental great horned owl

with an attitude about baseball caps, was grounded in 1986 with crooked wings, the result of rickets. The list is endless: hawks that have been shot, eagles that have been poisoned, owls that became entangled in fences. And the causes are painfully obvious. "All of these birds are here," says Barnhardt as he holds a maimed great horned owl, "because of what humans have done."

But if we have served parts of the natural world poorly, the Carolina Raptor Center is proof that we can make amends. One patient at a time, the CRC is helping to make sure that our skies will always carry birds of prey.

In the week following my visit, I learned that a pair of peregrine falcons that had nested at Hanging Rock State Park had moved on, the nest apparently a failure. A sad result, true enough, but I took heart in the bigger picture. Peregrines had never before nested at Hanging Rock. In fact, they had never nested anywhere nearby, and it wasn't so long ago that you wouldn't even see them in North Carolina. That they are here today and nesting is proof that recovery programs at places like the Carolina Raptor Center are working. I sure hope that

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those peregrines return next year. They nest in March, and I think that next spring I'll visit the CRC to see a peregrine up close. That way I'll know just what to marvel at next spring in the air over Hanging Rock.

Marshall Ellis lives in Raleigh.

If You're Going

The **Carolina Raptor Center** is a nonprofit facility whose programs are supported by donations from individuals, corporations, foundations, and the Arts and Science Council of Mecklenburg County. Memberships are available on a sliding fee schedule.

The center is located north of Charlotte at Latta Plantation Nature Preserve. Directions: from I-77, take exit 16B (Sunset Road, west) and turn right at the second light onto Beatties Ford Road. Go about 5 miles and turn left on Sample Road into the nature preserve. The center is 0.6 mile on the left.

Hours: 10 a.m. to 5 p.m., Tuesday through Saturday; noon to 5 p.m., Sunday. Admission: \$4 for adults, \$2 for senior citizens and students, free for CRC members.

In addition to the aviaries along the nature trail, birds are exhibited for close-up viewing and photography on Saturdays and Sundays. There are also regularly scheduled programs Monday through Friday, and groups of up to 55 can be accommodated. Program fees are \$2.50 per person; reservations are required. Special programs involving live birds, including the "Wild Wings" program, can also be arranged at your site or at the center. Contact the center for program types and fees.

For more information, contact:
Carolina Raptor Center
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